RABBENU AVRAHAM BEN HARAMBAM

Coming Back, Not Going Out: Yishak at Beer Lahai Roi

Rabbenu Avraham on Parashat Hayyei Sarah

Series: Rabbenu Avraham ben HaRambam on the Parashah: ideas from Rabbenu Avraham's commentary on the Torah (which survives on Bereshit and Shemot), taught each week at the Monday HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem shiur.

Source: Taught at the HaMaspik shiur of the week of Hayyei Sarah 5787, HaMaspik 10.3.

Topic: Why Yishak was *coming back* from **באר לחי ראי** when he met Rivkah, and why he moved there only **after Avraham's death**.

Part One — Rabbenu Avraham on Parashat Hayyei Sarah

The setting

Avraham sends his servant — called **עבד** throughout, identified as **Eliezer** — to find a wife for Yishak. Eliezer finds **Rivkah**, negotiates with her father and brother, **Betuel and Lavan**, and brings her home. As they travel back, Yishak has gone out **to meditate in the field** — *Hazal* tell us, to pray **Mincha** — and on his way back he meets Rivkah. She is in awe of him, and falls from the camel.

ויצחק בא מבוא באר לחי ראי, והוא יושב בארץ הנגב. (Bereshit 24:62)

Yishak was **living with his father in the Negev**, somewhere in the south — but he was **coming back from Beer Lahai Roi**.

Rabbenu Avraham's two questions:

1. **Why does the verse stress that he was *coming back*?**
2. **What is Beer Lahai Roi — and what was he doing there?**

1. Why "coming back" from Beer Lahai Roi?

אין ספק כי המרחק רב בין באר לחי ראי ובין המקום שאברהם ויצחק היו שוכנים בו.

There was **quite a distance** between Beer Lahai Roi and where Avraham and Yishak lived. So why go there?

אך יצחק רגיל להיפרד ממקום מושבו וללכת אל המדבר, אל הבאר הנזכרת, בדבקותו בעבודתו וחפצו לבקש התבודדות כדרך החסידים והנביאים, כמו שביארנו בספר המספיק בפרק ההתבודדות.

Yishak **regularly** left home and went out into the wilderness, to that well, **because of his attachment to his avodah and his wish for solitude** — the way of the righteous and the prophets. Rabbenu Avraham points to the **chapter on hitbodedut** in HaMaspik itself —

Chapter 12. (*We are in Chapter 10 now; there are 13 chapters. Chapter 12 is about the importance of quiet time alone — thinking, contemplating, meditating.*)

ויתעכב שם זמן קצר, ושוב היה חוזר למקום מושבו.

He would stay a short while, and then return home.

Why the emphasis on returning?

סיפר לנו הכתוב כי הפגישה הנזכרת היתה בזמן חזרת יצחק מהבאר, לא בזמן יציאתו. ועילת דבר זה, כפי הנראה לי — כדי להודיע לבני התורה שיצחק עליו השלום יצא לעבודתו, וחזר, משהגיעה רבקה עם אליעזר. ואילו היה פוגע בהם בהליכתו, לא היה חוזר מעבודתו; אלא היתה פגישתו עמהם אחר שגמר עבודתו.

The meeting happened on Yishak's way **back**, not on his way **out** — *"so that students of Torah should know"*: had he met them **on his way to his avodah**, he **would not have turned back** — **not even to meet his wife for the very first time**. He met them only because he had already finished.

	On the way out	**On the way back**
What Yishak was doing	Going to pray, meditate, be *mitboded*	Had finished his avodah
Would he have stopped for Rivkah?	**No** — he would not interrupt his avodah	**Yes** — and he did
What it teaches	How deeply **דבוק** he was in his avodah	

The Rabbi: this is the **awe** that Yishak clearly carried — an awe Rivkah saw, and fell from the camel because of it. He was so attached to his avodah that he only met her because he was already on his way home.

2. Why did Yishak move to Beer Lahai Roi — and why only after Avraham died?

The last verse in the parashah:

ויהי אחרי מות אברהם, ויברך אלהים את יצחק בנו, וישב יצחק עם באר לחי ראי. (25:11)

Until now he **visited** Beer Lahai Roi; **after Avraham's death he went to live there.**

ישיבתו של יצחק אצל הבאר — בשביל שהבחיר עליו השלום מצא שם עבודת השם; ובחיי אברהם לא היה יכול להיפרד ממנו, אלא היה חוזר ושב מאצל אביו אל הבאר ומן הבאר אצל אביו.

- **Why there?** Because Yishak found that **this was where he truly connected to Hakadosh Baruch Hu** — where his time alone developed his avodat Hashem.
- **Why only now?** Because while Avraham was alive, **he could not leave his father**. However much spiritual benefit he gained from his solitude, *"while my father is alive, I can't leave him."* So he travelled back and forth — though it took a great deal of his time — because **being with his father mattered**.

וכשנסתלק אברהם עליו השלום לעולם האמת, נסע יצחק וקבע מושבו אצל הבאר שבחר בה, בשביל סגולה שהיה מוצא שם.

Once Avraham passed away, Yishak **moved there** and settled by the well he had chosen, **because of the special quality he found there**.

The idea to take away

Before Rabbenu Avraham, we read **Beer Lahai Roi** as a random place name. It isn't. It is **the place where Yishak developed himself spiritually** — the place he would have lived all along — and he waited **only out of kibbud av**.

- **The significance of a place of solitude** for one's avodah.
- **The importance of honouring and looking after one's parents** — even above one's own spiritual preference.

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